Chapter 14

Freedom from Fear:
Creating a Blueprint for Prison Reform

AS ONE CLOSELY OBSERVES THE UNFOLDING OF KIRAN'S CAREER, A pattern in her responses becomes evident. The intensity of her responses are as per the demands of the situation. What is admirable and worth emulation is how she rises to the occasion every time, even when the situation is seemingly uninspiring, virtually invisible, big in scale yet neglected. The institution she dealt with could have poor resources. In fact, the observation is that the bigger the scale of the challenge, the greater is her achievement. The case in point is her historical reformation of corruption-ridden, drug-abusing, riotous, and overcrowded, under-resourced cluster of prisons, housing nearly 10,000 prisoners. Most of the inmates were men, barring a few hundred women, many with their children (below the age of four, who were permitted to stay with their mothers).

In this reformation process Kiran's potential and beliefs reached their zenith. When the government posted her as inspector general (IG) prisons, Tihar Jail, New Delhi, it was because there was no other place for her. The top authorities had to fit her somewhere. This was one place where they could 'fix' her and forget about her. Little did they anticipate that she was going to create history that would bequeath a very valuable legacy for prison systems for all time not only within India and but also internationally. And for her work she would receive Asia's most prestigious accolade: the Ramon Magsaysay Award for government service. (This award is also termed as the Asian Nobel Prize.)

The establishment of the Delhi jail can be traced to the British rule in India. During the Mughal times, close to the Khooni Darwaza (or Delhi Gate, located near Lal Qila or Red Fort), one Farid Khan had built a large inn for travellers passing through Delhi. When the British took over power, they requisitioned this inn and converted it into a jail (prison) mainly for the locality. However, as the Indian freedom movement gathered momentum from 1919 onwards, it led to the arrest of a large number of political prisoners whom the British had to accommodate. Thus, the local jail was upgraded to a 'district jail' in 1937. After India gained independence, this jail was shifted to a place near Tihar village, then on the outskirts of Delhi. A few years later, the jail was further upgraded to the status of a Central jail, which it still retains. However, its size and capacity have changed dramatically over the years. In 1958, Tihar Jail covered an area of 170 acres, which increased with the passage of time. In the early 1990s, it housed over 9800 plus inmates (mostly men except for 400 women), against a sanctioned capacity of only 2500.

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In the Indian Police Service a prison assignment for an IPS officer is considered to be a 'dump' posting. For Kiran it was a 'double dump' as she was denied a return to her own Delhi Police despite